Medieval England: 1066–1485

KNOWLEDGE RETRIEVAL • FORMATIVE TRACKING • HOMEWORK COMPANION • 40 QUESTIONS

Pupil Name: _____ **Class:** _____ **Teacher:** _____



Primary Visual Evidence: The Death of King Harold at Hastings (Bayeux Tapestry, c. 1070s • Bayeux Museum)

UNIT ENQUIRY SEQUENCE	ATT. 1	ATT. 2	RETRIEVAL STRENGTH	PARENT INITIALS
Enquiry 1: 1066 & Battle of Hastings *Why did William of Normandy win the Battle of Hastings in 1066?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	
Enquiry 2: Castles, Terror & Domesday *How did the Normans subjugate England and enforce total royal control?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	
Enquiry 3: Crown vs Church: Becket *Why did Henry II clash with Thomas Becket, and who triumphed?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	
Enquiry 4: Magna Carta & Kingship *Was Magna Carta a foundation of human liberty or a selfish barons' power grab?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	
Enquiry 5: Black Death & Peasants' Revolt *How did demographic catastrophe and peasant rebellion shatter the feudal order?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	

● **7–8/8 Mastered:** Secure factual recall. ● **5–6/8 Consolidate:** Flashcard restudy on missed terms. ● **<5/8 Action Required:** Mandatory re-test after DIRT corrections.

Scan for Interactive Digital Quizzes & Audio Lessons:
Access online self-marking retrieval flashcards, diagnostic feedback, and audio narration at **the-history-revision-hub.netlify.app**.

1. In what year did King Edward the Confessor die without leaving a direct heir? ▶

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

2. Who did the Anglo-Saxon Witan (council of nobles) choose to succeed Edward as King of England? ▶

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

3. At which battle in Yorkshire did King Harold defeat Viking invader Harald Hardrada in September 1066? ▶

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

4. Why did King Harold's victory at Stamford Bridge dangerously weaken his army for the Battle of Hastings? ▶▶

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

5. What defensive formation did the Anglo-Saxons form atop Senlac Hill that Norman cavalry repeatedly failed to break? ▶▶

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

6. How did the Normans use the tactic of the 'feigned retreat' to break the Anglo-Saxon shield wall? ▶▶

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

7. Why was Duke William's combined-arms army superior to King Harold's traditional Anglo-Saxon forces? ▶▶▶

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

8. How did contemporary Norman chronicler William of Poitiers interpret the collapse of the Saxon shield wall? ▶▶▶

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

9. ▶ What type of rapid, pre-fabricated castles did William build across England to intimidate Saxon populations?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

10. ▶ What brutal scorched-earth campaign did William conduct in 1069–1070 to crush northern rebellion?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

11. ▶ In what year was the exhaustive national audit known as the Domesday Book completed?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

12. ▶▶ Why was the Norman keep at Portchester Castle constructed inside an ancient Roman shore fort?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

13. ▶▶ How did the Norman feudal system completely replace the Anglo-Saxon ruling aristocracy?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

14. ▶▶ Why did Anglo-Saxons name William's comprehensive land and tax survey the 'Domesday Book'?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

15. ▶▶▶ How does chronicler Orderic Vitalis's account of the Harrying of the North challenge Norman triumphalism?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

16. ▶▶▶ What do local Domesday entries for Portchester, Fareham, and Titchfield reveal about the social impact of the Conquest?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

17. ▶ What high government position did Thomas Becket hold before Henry II appointed him Archbishop of Canterbury?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

18. ▶ What term described priests or churchmen accused of serious secular crimes such as murder or robbery?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

19. ▶ What 1164 royal document attempted to bring church courts and criminous clerks under royal jurisdiction?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

20. ▶▶ Why did Becket violently oppose the Constitutions of Clarendon after becoming Archbishop?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

21. ▶▶ What words did Henry II famously shout in anger that prompted four knights to ride to Canterbury?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

22. ▶▶ On what date was Thomas Becket murdered inside Canterbury Cathedral?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

23. ▶▶▶ How did Becket's murder transform European public opinion and weaken King Henry II's power?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

24. ▶▶▶ Why did Henry II allow eighty Canterbury monks to whip him with rods during his 1174 penance?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

25. ▶ What insulting nickname did King John earn after losing Normandy and Anjou to King Philip Augustus of France?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

26. ▶ What feudal tax paid by barons in place of providing military knights did King John raise eleven times in sixteen years?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

27. ▶ At which decisive 1214 battle in Flanders was King John's allied army crushed by the French King Philip Augustus?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

28. ▶▶ Where and on what date did King John meet rebel barons to grant and seal Magna Carta?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

29. ▶▶ What fundamental legal principle did Clause 39 of Magna Carta establish?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

30. ▶▶ Why did Pope Innocent III annul Magna Carta just two months after it was sealed?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

31. ▶▶▶ Why do modern historians debate whether Magna Carta was a declaration of universal human rights or a selfish barons' charter?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

32. ▶▶▶ How did Simon de Montfort's 1265 Parliament build upon the constitutional legacy of Magna Carta?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

33. ▶ What bacterium was responsible for the pandemic known to history as the Black Death?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

34. ▶ In what English port did the Black Death first arrive in the summer of 1348?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

35. ▶ Approximately what percentage of the English population died during the 1348–1350 Black Death?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

36. ▶▶ Why did the demographic collapse caused by the Black Death dramatically shift economic power toward surviving peasants?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

37. ▶▶ What 1351 parliamentary law attempted to freeze peasant wages at pre-plague (1346) levels and punish fleeing workers?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

38. ▶▶ What regressive tax levied in 1377, 1379, and 1381 sparked the outbreak of the Peasants' Revolt?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

39. ▶▶▶ How did radical priest John Ball's preaching challenge the entire medieval feudal hierarchy?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

40. ▶▶▶ Why was the Peasants' Revolt a turning point even though Wat Tyler was murdered and its leaders executed?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

Department Marking Bank • Part 1: Enquiries 1–3 (Q1–Q20)

ENQUIRY 1: 1066 & THE BATTLE OF HASTINGS (Q1–Q8)

1. ▶ **1066 (5 January 1066)** — Edward the Confessor's death on 5 January 1066 triggered an immediate three-way succession crisis for the English throne.

2. ▶ **Harold Godwinson, Earl of Wessex** — Harold was crowned King Harold II the day after Edward died, claiming Edward had promised him the throne on his deathbed.

3. ▶ **The Battle of Stamford Bridge** — Harold surprised the Viking invaders on 25 September 1066, killing Hardrada and crushing the last major Norse invasion of England.

4. ▶▶ **His army suffered heavy casualties and had to march 200 miles south in just two weeks to confront William** — Harold's elite housecarls were depleted, and his fyrd peasant levies were exhausted by the 400-mile round trip before facing fresh Norman cavalry.

5. ▶▶ **The shield wall** — The housecarls and fyrd locked their heavy wooden shields together along the ridge, creating an impenetrable barrier against Norman arrows and horses.

6. ▶▶ **Norman cavalry pretended to flee downhill, tricking undisciplined Saxons into breaking ranks to pursue them** — When Saxon fyrdmen charged down the hill chasing the retreating Normans, Norman cavalry wheeled around and encircled them on open ground.

7. ▶▶▶ **William combined heavy cavalry with stirrups, archers, and infantry, whereas Harold relied solely on a stationary infantry shield wall** — Norman tactical flexibility and archers firing high into the air forced the Saxons to look up, exposing them to cavalry charges and fatal arrow wounds.

8. ▶▶▶ **As divine punishment for Harold's broken sacred oath to support William's claim to the throne** — Norman propaganda claimed Harold was a perjurer who swore holy relics at Bayeux, justifying William's conquest as God's providential judgement.

ENQUIRY 2: CASTLES, TERROR & DOMESDAY (Q9–Q16)

9. ▶ **Motte-and-bailey castles** — Using earth mounds (mottes) and wooden palisades (baileys), Norman garrisons could erect a fortress within eight to ten days.

10. ▶ **The Harrying of the North** — William ordered crops burned, livestock slaughtered, and fields salted across Yorkshire and the north, causing over 100,000 people to starve.

11. ▶ **1086** — Commissioned by William at Gloucester in 1085, Domesday recorded every manor, ox, mill, and woodland across England to maximize tax revenue.

12. ▶▶ **To exploit 1,700-year-old Roman stone walls and command the deep-water sea approaches to Portsmouth Harbour** — Portchester provided a secure military landing and embarkation port between England and Normandy, combining Roman defense with Norman power.

13. ▶▶ **All land was declared property of the King, who redistributed it to around 200 Norman tenants-in-chief in exchange for military service** — Over 4,000 Anglo-Saxon thegns were dispossessed by 1086, reducing English landowners to less than 5% of the kingdom's soil.

14. ▶▶ **Because its legal verdicts were final and unchangeable, like the Day of Judgement (Doomsday)** — No appeal was permitted against the commissioners' written records, symbolising the inescapable judicial power of the Norman Crown.

15. ▶▶▶ **Although half-Norman himself, Vitalis condemned William's barbarous slaughter and predicted God would avenge the innocent victims** — Vitalis wrote that William's brutal starvation of women and children was a sin that no earthly crown or military glory could excuse.

16. ▶▶▶ **They record English landholders being demoted to sub-tenants or displaced entirely by Norman lords like William d'Arques** — Local manorial records provide forensic proof that the Conquest was not a peaceful transition but a total redistribution of wealth and power.

ENQUIRY 3: CROWN VS CHURCH: BECKET (Q17–Q20)

17. ▶ **Lord Chancellor of England** — Becket was Henry's closest friend, lavish companion, and chief advisor, helping the king rebuild royal finances and enforce crown law.

18. ▶ **Criminous clerks** — In the 12th century, roughly one-sixth of England's male population claimed clerical status to escape royal hanging in secular courts.

19. ▶ **The Constitutions of Clarendon** — Henry II demanded that clerks accused of felony be tried in royal courts and, if guilty, stripped of holy orders and punished by royal judges.

20. ▶▶ **He believed in canon law and argued that punishing a clerk in a secular court violated God's law by punishing a man twice for one offence** — Becket's sudden spiritual transformation led him to defend the total autonomy of the Catholic Church against secular royal intrusion.

Department Marking Bank • Part 2: Enquiries 3–5 (Q21–Q40)

ENQUIRY 3: CROWN VS CHURCH: BECKET (Q21–Q24)

21. ▶▶ **'Will no one rid me of this turbulent priest?' (or words to that effect)** — Henry's furious outburst at his Christmas court in Bures led Reginald FitzUrse and three fellow knights to travel across the Channel to assassinate Becket.

22. ▶▶ **29 December 1170** — The four knights confronted Becket in the cathedral, drawing swords and hacking him to death at the altar when he refused to lift his excommunications.

23. ▶▶▶ **Becket was instantly revered as a martyr and canonised as a saint in 1173, forcing Henry to abandon the Constitutions of Clarendon** — Christendom was horrified by cathedral bloodshed; pilgrims flocked to Becket's shrine, and Henry was forced to perform public barefoot penance.

24. ▶▶▶ **To prove his sincere remorse to the Pope, secure absolution, and rally divine support during a dangerous rebellion by his sons** — Facing simultaneous invasions by the Scots, the French king, and his own rebel sons, Henry used dramatic religious submission to restore royal legitimacy.

ENQUIRY 4: MAGNA CARTA & MEDIEVAL KINGSHIP (Q25–Q32)

25. ▶ **'John Lackland' or 'John Softsword'** — By 1204, John had lost almost all the ancestral continental territories built up by his father Henry II and brother Richard the Lionheart.

26. ▶ **Scutage ('shield money')** — John used aggressive scutage extortion and exorbitant inheritance fines ('reliefs') to fund his ruinously expensive French military campaigns.

27. ▶ **The Battle of Bouvines** — Bouvines ended John's hopes of reconquering Normandy, emptied the English treasury, and convinced the English barons that the King was militarily incompetent.

28. ▶▶ **At Runnymede on 15 June 1215** — Surrounded by rebel barons calling themselves the 'Army of God', John met them in the water-meadows of Runnymede beside the River Thames.

29. ▶▶ **That no free man could be seized, imprisoned, or stripped of possessions except by the lawful judgment of his equals or by the law of the land** — Clause 39 established the Rule of Law: the revolutionary precedent that even the king was subject to legal due process and could not act arbitrarily.

30. ▶▶ **He declared it illegal and shameful because it had been extracted from an anointed king by armed coercion and rebellion** — Having previously allied with John, the Pope released the king from his oath, plunging England immediately into the First Barons' War.

31. ▶▶▶ **Because in 1215 it protected only the narrow privileges of 'free men' (barons and churchmen), while 80% of the population were unfree serfs** — Serfs and villeins gained no personal liberty from the 1215 charter; however, its legal principles were reinterpreted across centuries into universal civil rights.

32. ▶▶▶ **It summoned two elected knights from every shire and two burgesses from every borough, establishing the foundation of the House of Commons** — De Montfort expanded political representation beyond the great barons, linking parliamentary taxation to wider popular representation.

ENQUIRY 5: THE BLACK DEATH & PEASANTS' REVOLT (Q33–Q40)

33. ▶ **Yersinia pestis** — Carried by oriental rat fleas living on black rats, Yersinia pestis attacked lymph nodes to cause bubonic plague, or lungs to cause pneumonic plague.

34. ▶ **Melcombe Regis (Weymouth), Dorset** — A ship arriving from Gascony brought infected sailors and fleas ashore in June 1348, rapidly spreading infection across the kingdom.

35. ▶ **Between 35% and 50% (roughly 1.5 to 2.5 million people)** — Whole villages were abandoned, crops rotted in untilled fields, and parish clergy died in vast numbers administering last rites.

36. ▶▶ **The acute labour shortage meant landowners had to compete for workers by paying higher cash wages and lowering rents** — For the first time in medieval history, serfs and labourers could negotiate higher pay or walk away to neighboring manors desperate for harvest workers.

37. ▶▶ **The Statute of Labourers** — Passed by land-owning MPs, the statute imposed fines, imprisonment, and even branding with a hot iron 'F' (for Falsity) on peasants demanding wage rises.

38. ▶▶ **The Poll Tax (head tax)** — To pay for the Hundred Years' War against France, Parliament taxed every person over fourteen equally, forcing poor peasants to pay the same as wealthy lords.

39. ▶▶▶ **He argued that God created all men equal, asking: 'When Adam delved and Eve span, who was then the gentleman?'** — Ball attacked the divine right of lords to hold men in bondage, demanding the abolition of serfdom, equal wealth distribution, and church land confiscation.

40. ▶▶▶ **Parliament never dared to pass another poll tax, and landlords were forced to gradually commute serfdom into free wage labour** — Although Richard II crushed the rebels, fear of renewed peasant uprising prevented landowners from enforcing feudal servitude, leading to the extinction of serfdom.